

ConnectBox Translations Guide

Version 2 – Oct 7, 2026. Replaces the 5 Oct 2026 guide: the master file `interface_translations.json` and `apply_translations.py` it described have been retired.

What is translated

The menu's own wording (section titles, media type names, the Language button, the Configuration link, the chat labels, the "Loading new content" page and the "Speaker notes" label on presentations) is shown in the language the visitor chose. The ConnectBox software only has this wording in English, so the translations are kept in one file per language on the unit.

How it works

- Each time a USB drive is loaded, the content loader (`mmiLoader.py`) writes the menu wording for every language folder on the drive from `/usr/local/connectbox/translations/<code>.json` (for example `es.json`). This also happens on a quick load from `saved.zip`, so a correction shows up without re-indexing.
- Reviewed files are installed with the software for **Farsi (fa)**, **Arabic (ar)**, **Spanish (es)**, **Portuguese (pt)** and **Chinese (zh-CN)**. Their source is `ansible/roles/bootstrap/files/translations/` in the connectbox-pi repository.
- For any other language, if the unit has internet, the English wording is translated online once (MyMemory, no account needed) and saved in a new file there, so it keeps working offline. With no internet the menu stays in English and the lookup is tried again on the next USB insert.
- Right-to-left languages (Arabic, Farsi, Hebrew, Urdu, Pashto, Sindhi, Kurdish Sorani, Uyghur, Yiddish, Dhivehi) are marked automatically, so the page flips direction.
- Language folder names are matched to these files through the language code list on the unit, so folders named with 3-letter codes (`spa`, `ara`, `per`) also find the right file.

The translation files

Each file lists every label with three values:

- **en** – the English the translation was made from. If the English changes in a later software version, that label is translated again; otherwise a corrected **text** is never replaced.
- **text** – the wording shown on screen. This is the value to correct.
- **source** – where the wording came from, for example "reviewed on test unit 2026-10-05" or "native check advised".

Label key	English	Where it appears
<code>CATEGORIES_TITLE</code>	Categories	Section title
<code>CHAT_MESSAGE</code>	Type a message	Chat message box
<code>CHAT_NAME</code>	Name	Chat name box
<code>CHAT_TITLE</code>	Chat	Chat page title

EPISODES_TEXT	Episodes	Collection pages
FOOTER_CONFIGURATION	Configuration	Bottom-left link
INDEXING_TEXT	This ConnectBox is loading new media. The menu will appear here by itself when it is ready.	Loading page
INDEXING_TITLE	Loading new content	Loading page
LANGUAGE_BUTTON	Language	Header button
MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION	App	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.AUDIO	Audio	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.DOCUMENT	Document	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.HTML	Web Document	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.IMAGE	Image	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.TEXT	Text File	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.VIDEO	Video	Card and detail labels
MEDIA_TYPE.ZIP	Archive	Card and detail labels
MISSING_MEDIA_TEXT	We're working on collecting the data or Something went wrong! The media is missing!	Error page
MISSING_MEDIA_TITLE	Media is missing!	Error page
OTHER_MEDIA_TITLE	Media	Section title
RECOMMENDED_TEXT	Recommended	Home page
RECOMMENDED_TITLE	For You	Home page
SLIDE_NOTES	Speaker notes	Presentation pages
UNSUPPORTED_TEXT	Sorry, your browser does not support videos.	Video player

Correcting a translation

A fix made only on a unit is lost when the unit is re-provisioned with Ansible, so make lasting fixes in the repository as well.

On a unit:

1. Log in: `ssh root@<unit address>`.
2. Keep a copy: `cp /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json /root/es.json.bak` (use the language's code).
3. Edit only the `text` value of the label: `nano /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json`. Keep the quotes and commas as they are, and set `source` to say who checked it.
4. Check the file: `python3 -m json.tool /usr/local/connectbox/translations/es.json > /dev/null && echo OK`.
5. Unplug and re-insert the USB drive (or restart the unit). The menu is rewritten with the new wording; a normal browser refresh shows it.

For all future units: make the same change in

`ansible/roles/bootstrap/files/translations/<code>.json`, commit and push.

Adding a language

Put the content in a folder named with the language code (for example `fr`). If the unit is online during the first load, the labels are looked up and saved in `/usr/local/connectbox/translations/fr.json`. Online translations of short menu words are often poor, so have a native speaker check that file, then copy it into

the repository folder above so every unit gets the reviewed version. You can also write the file yourself first (copy `es.json`, set `language`, and replace each `text`); the unit then does not look anything up.

Waiting for a native speaker check

Language	Labels marked "native check advised"
Arabic (ar)	LANGUAGE_BUTTON, MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION, INDEXING_TITLE, INDEXING_TEXT, SLIDE_NOTES
Spanish (es)	LANGUAGE_BUTTON, MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION, INDEXING_TITLE, INDEXING_TEXT, SLIDE_NOTES
Farsi (fa)	all 24 labels
Portuguese (pt)	LANGUAGE_BUTTON, MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION, INDEXING_TITLE, INDEXING_TEXT, SLIDE_NOTES
Chinese (zh-CN)	LANGUAGE_BUTTON, MEDIA_TYPE.APPLICATION, INDEXING_TITLE, INDEXING_TEXT, SLIDE_NOTES

What is not translated

- Content titles (books, videos, PDFs) – they come from the file and folder names on the USB drive.
- The "ConnectBox" name in the header – it comes from the unit's brand setting.
- Language button names (Español, العربية, 中文 ...) – they come from the language name list on the unit (`languageCodes.json`), not from these files.
- Chat messages – shown as typed; only their text direction follows the sender's language.